

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE

Hanwha Aerospace

South Korea

Engineering Interview Preparation Guide

Targeted for the 2025–2026 Recruitment Cycle

Hanwha Aerospace is one of the most distinctive and least-understood companies in this series from a Western perspective — a Korean chaebol subsidiary that is simultaneously Korea's only indigenous gas turbine engine developer, the system integrator for Korea's national launch vehicle, a globally dominant artillery manufacturer, and an aggressive acquirer of Western defence and aerospace assets. This guide consolidates the preparation tasks, signal areas, and strategic context needed to compete effectively across all relevant engineering roles.

PART I · WHAT HANWHA AEROSPACE ACTUALLY LOOKS FOR

By Seniority Level

- **Sinip Sa'won (New Graduate / Sinip)** — Hanwha Aerospace's new graduate selection is multi-stage, formal, and explicitly anchored to the company's stated talent profile: the "Next Great Challenger" (*widaehan dojeonja* ()). The recruitment process runs: document screening → aptitude test (*injokseong geomsa* ()) → 1st interview → 2nd interview → health examination → final acceptance. For R&D roles specifically, the 1st interview takes the form of a PT (presentation) interview. The aptitude test is the first hard filter — it assesses numerical reasoning, spatial reasoning, problem-solving, and personality dimensions. Candidates who underperform do not reach the interview stage regardless of academic credentials.

At graduate level, Hanwha Aerospace screens for three things: academic technical depth in a relevant engineering or science discipline (*gonghaek ttoeneun igongye jeonong* ()), demonstrated commitment to the specific engineering domain rather than employment at any large company, and the cultural fit that a chaebol environment requires — hierarchy awareness, team contribution over individual glory, and a genuine commitment to Korea's national technology sovereignty agenda. Foreign students applying through the international student track must demonstrate Korean language proficiency at TOPIK Level 4 or above.

- **Gyeongnyeok Sa'won (Experienced Mid-Level Hire, ~3–10 years)** — Mid-level experienced hire applications go through hanwhain.com, followed by 1–2 rounds of interviews focused on in-depth verification of expertise based on the applicant's job experience. The technical interview at this level is domain-specific and experience-walk-through oriented — the hiring manager wants to know what you have actually designed, analysed, or tested, and whether that experience maps directly to what their team is working on. The PT (presentation) interview format for R&D roles means mid-level R&D candidates must prepare a formal presentation of their technical background, key achievements, and how their experience connects to the target role.

The specific context that makes experienced hire preparation different in 2025–2026: Hanwha Aerospace is in an extraordinary growth phase. Operating profit broke through the 3 trillion won (approximately \$2.2 billion USD) level in 2025. The K9 Thunder self-propelled howitzer programme has contracts with

India, Poland, Romania, and others. The KF-21 Boramae fighter engine programme has a \$401 million contract for the first mass-production batch. The KSLV-II Nuri rocket's fourth launch was completed in 2025, and Hanwha Aerospace was selected as system integrator for the KSLV-III next-generation launch vehicle. This growth is creating hiring demand across every division simultaneously.

- **Suchok / Jeonmun Wiwo (Senior / Principal Engineer)** — At senior level, Hanwha Aerospace is looking for engineers who can carry technical authority for programmes that are either Korea's first in their category or competing directly against established Western players for the first time. The gas turbine engine design and analysis team performs aerodynamic design of compressor, combustor, and turbine main components, determines their geometry, and evaluates thermal/structural life — work described as “irreplaceable” and available at no other Korean company. Senior engineers are expected to have either developed irreplaceable Korean expertise in a domain, or to have brought external expertise that Korea lacks and can now develop internally. The DAPA (*Bangwi Saueop Cheong* (Defence Acquisition Program Administration)) relationship governs the military programme interface and requires senior engineers who can represent Hanwha Aerospace's technical position credibly in government programme reviews.

Hands-On Signal Areas

Domain	Core Competencies Expected
Gas Turbine Engine Design	Hanwha Aerospace is described as Korea's only private company capable of both developing and manufacturing aerospace gas turbine engines. Aerodynamic design of compressors, combustors, and turbines, CFD analysis, rig testing, and engine-level testing are live hiring needs. Engineers with GE, P&W, or Rolls-Royce subcontracting or development backgrounds who bring specific component expertise are specifically valued.
RSP Programme Experience	Hanwha Aerospace participates as RSP with GE (GenX), Rolls-Royce (Trent 1000), and P&W (GTF) for component manufacture and development. The RSP programme involves joint development of high-value components, with the goal of developing proprietary manufacturing capability over decades. Engineers with experience in these specific engine families are directly relevant.
Korean Language Fluency	Korean is the working language at Changwon and Seongnam headquarters. Engineering design reviews, supplier meetings, DAPA programme reviews, and daily team work all happen in Korean. Engineers without Korean proficiency face a structural disadvantage that cannot be resolved by technical competence alone.
Launch Vehicle Propulsion / Structures	Hanwha Aerospace manufactures all six liquid rocket engines for the KSLV-II Nuri rocket, including the 75-tonne-class Kerosene/LOX engines, propellant feed valves, attitude control systems, and propulsion test facilities. As KSLV-III system integrator, Hanwha Aerospace is developing reusable launch vehicle technology.
DAPA Defence Programme Experience	Knowledge of Korea's Defence Acquisition Program Administration process — the Korean equivalent of the US DoD acquisition framework, the UK MOD, or France's DGA — is valued for defence-track roles. Defence Development Roadmap, DREX programme reviews, and MRO contracts all involve DAPA interface.
KF-21 Boramae Avionics / Propulsion	The KF-21 is Korea's indigenous 4.5-generation fighter, with Hanwha Aerospace providing the engine through a GE partnership while localising key components. Engine integration, systems interface, and flight test support are active engineering domains.
International Defence Export Knowledge	With K9 deployed in 10 countries and growing export momentum, engineers with knowledge of export programme management, offset agreement structures, and overseas licensed production are relevant to the Land Systems business.

How Hanwha Aerospace's Interview Format Differs from Standard Tech and Other Companies

- **The aptitude test (*injokseong geomsa* (인적성검사)) is a hard first filter that cannot be bypassed.** Hanwha Group administers its own proprietary aptitude test (HAT — Hanwha Aptitude Test), which tests numerical reasoning, verbal reasoning, spatial reasoning, and situational judgement. Performance on this test determines whether candidates proceed to the interview stage.

- **The PT (presentation) interview is mandatory for all R&D roles.** For R&D positions, the first interview takes the form of a PT interview (*balpyo myeonjeop* ()) where candidates present their technical background and achievements. The panel is composed of engineers from the relevant technical team, and follow-up questions probe depth and reasoning.
- **The interview is conducted in Korean for Korean-site roles.** This is not a preference — it is a practical requirement. The panel consists of Korean engineers who will conduct the entire interview in Korean. Written materials submitted as part of the PT interview are also in Korean.
- **Military service completion is a listed requirement for Korean male applicants.** Hanwha Aerospace's hiring explicitly requires that applicants must have fulfilled or be exempted from compulsory military service and be fit for international travel. This applies to Korean male candidates. Female candidates and foreign nationals are exempt from this requirement.
- **The chaebol culture shapes interview expectations in ways that differ from Western companies.** Hanwha Group is one of Korea's major *chaebol* (large diversified conglomerate) — with strong hierarchical structures, a clear expectation of collective contribution over individual recognition, and a culture that values loyalty and organisational commitment. Interview answers that frame individual achievement without acknowledging team contribution, or that signal primarily self-interested career motivation, do not align with chaebol professional values.
- **The “Next Great Challenger” (*widaehan dojeonja* ()) framing is evaluated throughout.** Hanwha Aerospace explicitly markets itself as a company working on Korea's most challenging frontiers. Candidates who can articulate why they want to work on this specific frontier — Korean aerospace sovereignty, not just space or defence employment — are demonstrating the mission alignment the company explicitly recruits for.
- **For international roles (Hanwha Defense USA, Hanwha Aerospace USA) the format is closer to standard US defence hiring.** Roles in Virginia, Ohio, Pennsylvania, and other US locations follow US hiring norms — no Korean aptitude test, English-language interviews, standard resume submission. These roles require US persons under ITAR. The guide below focuses on Korean-site roles.

Honest caveat on format variation: Hanwha Aerospace operates across multiple distinct business divisions — Aerospace (gas turbine engines, MRO), Space (launch vehicles), Land Systems (artillery, armoured vehicles), Defence Electronics (fire control, radar, air defence), and Naval (through Hanwha Ocean). Each division has distinct technical cultures and hiring priorities. The detailed interview questions, technical depth, and cultural expectations differ by division. This guide focuses on the Aerospace (gas turbine) and Space (launch vehicle) divisions, which are the most internationally distinctive.

PART II · 20 SPECIFIC PREPARATION TASKS

Sinip Sa'won / New Graduate

1. Prepare for the Hanwha HAT Aptitude Test — Numerical, Verbal, Spatial Reasoning, and SJT 4–6 h

Skill: Aptitude test performance as the primary early filter

Objective: The aptitude test is the first scored gate. Candidates who do not pass do not reach the interview stage regardless of academic credentials or technical depth. Korean chaebol aptitude tests share format characteristics — numerical reasoning using data tables, verbal reasoning from pas-

sage comprehension, spatial reasoning using pattern completion or 3D object manipulation — and practice under timed conditions directly improves performance. 4–6 h

Done Signal: You have completed at least four full-length practice HAT or equivalent Korean chae-bol aptitude tests (Samsung GSAT, LG *injokseong* () formats are similar) under timed conditions, scored each, identified your weakest test type, and completed targeted practice on that weakness. Your average across three final practice tests is above the 70th percentile on all sub-tests.

Spread over multiple days.

2. Develop Korean Technical Communication to Professional Fluency — Specifically Engineering Vocabulary in Your Discipline Months (ongoing)

Skill: Working language readiness for a Korean-dominant professional environment

Objective: The interview, the PT presentation, and daily work at Korean sites all happen in Korean. Technical vocabulary in aerodynamics (*gongnyeok seolgye* (aerodynamic design)), gas turbine components (*apchukgi, yeonsogi, teobin* (compressor, combustor, turbine)), structures (*gujo haesok* (structural analysis)), launch vehicle propulsion (*aeke roket engin* (liquid rocket engine)), and defence systems (*jajupoe, yudo muki* (self-propelled howitzer, guided weapons)) must be fluent. Candidates who know their engineering domain in English but cannot discuss it in Korean cannot participate effectively in Korean team environments.

Done Signal: You can deliver a 10-minute technical explanation of a project or concept in your engineering domain — entirely in Korean — and answer follow-up questions in Korean without reverting to English for technical terms. A native Korean-speaking engineer has confirmed your technical vocabulary is adequate for professional use.

3. Prepare the PT (*Balpyo Myeonjeop*) Presentation — a Formal Presentation of Your Technical Background and Key Achievement 5–6 h

Skill: The primary technical selection event for R&D roles

Objective: For R&D positions, the first interview takes the form of a PT (presentation) interview where the panel evaluates technical depth, communication clarity, and relevance to the target role. The presentation must cover: your academic and professional background, your most significant technical achievement, how your specific expertise connects to Hanwha Aerospace's technical needs, and what you want to contribute. The entire presentation must be in Korean, with Korean-language slides.

Done Signal: You have a 10–15-minute Korean-language presentation that: opens with a clear framing of your technical background and target role, describes your most significant technical achievement with specific numbers and engineering details, connects your expertise to one specific Hanwha Aerospace programme or technical challenge, and ends with what you specifically want to contribute. You have delivered it twice to Korean engineers who then asked three follow-up questions each that you answered without going blank.

4. Know Hanwha Aerospace's Four Main Business Areas at Technical Depth — Aerospace, Space, Land Systems, Defence Electronics 5–6 h

Skill: Division-level programme knowledge for the PT presentation and interview

Objective: Hanwha Aerospace explicitly frames its recruiting narrative around “irreplaceable” Korean-first capabilities — particularly aerospace gas turbine engine development and manufacture, which it describes as uniquely its own in Korea. Candidates who can name specific programmes,

5–6 h

describe the engineering challenge, and explain why this work is uniquely available at Hanwha Aerospace are demonstrating the kind of institutional engagement that distinguishes a motivated candidate from a generalist one.

Done Signal: For each of the four divisions — Aerospace (KF-21 engine, RSP programmes, GTE MRO), Space (KSLV-II Nuri, KSLV-III, reusable launch vehicle), Land Systems (K9 Thunder, K21, Chunmoo), Defence Electronics (H-SHORAD, M-SAM, L-SAM) — you can state: the primary product, its current programme phase, one specific engineering challenge, and why Hanwha Aerospace’s role is uniquely significant in Korea’s industrial context. You can do this in Korean.

4–5 h

5. Understand the *Jagi Sogaeseo* (Self-Introduction Essay) Format and Prepare Answers That Connect to Hanwha Aerospace’s Specific Values

Skill: Written application quality — the first document screening

Objective: Korean chaebol applications include a *jagi sogaeseo* (self-introduction essay) that typically asks: why you chose this field, your most significant achievement, a challenge you overcame, and why you want to work at Hanwha Aerospace specifically. These are scored during document screening. Generic answers that could apply to Samsung, LG, or any chaebol are recognised immediately. The expected answer for Hanwha Aerospace specifically connects to the “Next Great Challenger” identity — the aspiration to work on Korea’s first and only capabilities in aerospace sovereignty.

Done Signal: You have written four *jagi sogaeseo* () answers — one per typical question type — each tailored specifically to Hanwha Aerospace. Each names a specific Hanwha Aerospace programme, connects your background to it technically, and frames your motivation in terms of contributing to Korea’s aerospace technological independence, not just personal career advancement. A native Korean speaker has reviewed each for language quality and cultural appropriateness.

3 h

6. Understand the Structure and Significance of the Nuri (*Nurihho* / KSLV-II) Programme and Hanwha Aerospace’s Specific Role

Skill: Korea’s national space launch vehicle — the most visible manifestation of Hanwha Aerospace’s “first in Korea” identity

Objective: In 2022, Hanwha Aerospace was appointed system integrator for the Korean Launch Vehicle Advancement Project, successfully supported the third Nuri launch in 2023 and the fourth in 2025, and was selected as system integrator for KSLV-III in 2024. The Nuri programme is a national symbol of Korean space sovereignty — Korea developed the rocket entirely independently after technology transfer restrictions prevented relying on foreign expertise. Candidates for any space-related role who cannot describe this context are demonstrating they have not engaged with the mission they are applying to join.

Done Signal: You can explain what KSLV-II (Nuri) is, what Hanwha Aerospace’s specific role was (system integrator, all six liquid rocket engines, propellant feed systems, attitude control), what KSLV-III represents as the next programme, and why the independent development of Korea’s launch vehicle matters for national space sovereignty. You can do this in Korean.

Gyeongnyeok Sa’won / Mid-Level Experienced Hire

All graduate tasks still apply. Korean language must be professional working fluency for Korean-site roles. The PT presentation must cover professional project work, not academic projects. Technical knowledge must extend to current programme phase and specific engineering challenges.

7. Build Working Knowledge of Korean Gas Turbine Engine Programmes — KF-21 Engine, KUH Surion Engine, and RSP Partnerships 4–5 h

Skill: Korean aviation propulsion context — the core of Hanwha Aerospace's most technically unique division

Objective: Hanwha Aerospace has produced over 10,000 engines including engines for the F-15K, T-50 advanced jet trainer, and the indigenised engine for the KUH Surion utility helicopter — and is leading the development of an integrated engine for the KF-21 fighter through a GE partnership while localising key components. The KF-21 engine development is specifically significant: Korea is the only Asian country outside Japan with a programme to develop indigenous high-performance military jet engine technology. Engineers who understand what is technically novel about this effort — and what gaps Korea still has compared to GE, P&W, or Rolls-Royce — are demonstrating the depth Hanwha Aerospace needs.

Done Signal: You can explain Hanwha Aerospace's engine portfolio (MRO origins in 1979, license production for F-15K and T-50, indigenisation for KUH Surion, KF-21 engine development partnership with GE), describe what the KF-21 engine development involves technically (turbofan class, GE partnership structure, localisation targets), and explain why Korea's gas turbine technology development is strategically important for KF-21 operational independence. You can do this in Korean.

8. Prepare a Story About Your Experience with Gas Turbine Component Design, Analysis, or Testing — Connected to Hanwha Aerospace's Specific Capability Gaps 2–3 h

Skill: Technical contribution evidence for Korea's most critical aerospace technology development need

Objective: Hanwha Aerospace's gas turbine design and analysis team is described as performing irreplaceable work — aerodynamic design of compressor, combustor, and turbine components, thermal/structural life evaluation — that cannot be done at any other Korean company. The company is specifically seeking engineers who can close capability gaps in this domain, whether from Korean academia (KAIST, Seoul National University, POSTECH) or from experience at Western OEMs (GE, P&W, Rolls-Royce, Safran, MTU). The story must demonstrate that your specific technical contribution would close a gap, not just add capacity.

Done Signal: You have a story about gas turbine component design, CFD analysis, structural life assessment, or rig testing that demonstrates a technical capability directly relevant to one of Hanwha Aerospace's engine programmes. The story names the specific component (compressor, combustor, turbine, bearings, seals), the analysis method used, the key result, and — crucially — how your specific expertise addresses something Korea currently cannot do independently.

9. Understand DAPA (*Bangwi Saueop Cheong*) and the Korean Defence Acquisition Process 3–4 h

Skill: Korean defence programme governance framework

Objective: Hanwha Aerospace's defence programmes — K9, KF-21, KSLV, H-SHORAD, M-SAM, L-SAM — are all governed by the Defence Acquisition Program Administration (*Bangwi Saueop Cheong* (DAPA)). DAPA manages requirements, contracts, and acceptance for all Korean defence procurement, analogously to the US DoD Acquisition Executive, the UK DE&S, or France's DGA. Engineers who understand how DAPA programme reviews work, how specifications are negotiated, and how acceptance criteria are agreed will contribute to programme management discussions from their first week.

Done Signal: You can explain what DAPA is and its role in Korean defence acquisition, describe the Korean equivalent of the US CDR/PDR milestone structure, explain how the Korean Defence Development Roadmap (*Gukbang Gwahak Gisul Hyeoksin Chokjin Beop* ()) shapes Hanwha Aerospace's

R&D investment priorities, and describe what *bangsantwonga* (defence cost calculation) means for pricing Korean defence contracts. 3–4 h

10. Study the RSP (Risk Sharing Partner) Business Model — and What It Means for Hanwha Aerospace's Long-Term Technology Development 3 h

Skill: Understanding the engine component export programme that funds technology development

Objective: Hanwha Aerospace participates as RSP in GE (GEnX), Rolls-Royce (Trent), and P&W (GTF) engine programmes, manufacturing high-value components as a programme partner rather than a simple supplier. This is not just a revenue stream — it is the mechanism by which Hanwha Aerospace engineers gain hands-on experience with the most advanced engine technology in the world, build proprietary manufacturing capability, and ultimately close the gap toward fully indigenous engine development. Engineers who understand the RSP model — its commercial structure, its technology transfer implications, and its strategic role in Korean aerospace development — are demonstrating the long-term thinking that Hanwha Aerospace's strategy requires.

Done Signal: You can explain what an RSP programme structure involves (shared development investment, revenue sharing, defined workshare), why Hanwha Aerospace pursued RSP with GE/P&W/R-R specifically, what technology and capability Hanwha Aerospace gains through these partnerships, and how RSP experience contributes to KF-21 engine indigenisation capability. You can discuss this in Korean.

11. Prepare a Story About Working on a Programme with a Government Customer — Specifically Managing Technical Requirements and Acceptance Criteria 1–2 h

Skill: Government programme interface experience in a defence acquisition context

Objective: All of Hanwha Aerospace's military programmes involve close interface with DAPA, the Korean Armed Forces (ROK Army, Air Force, Navy), or in international programmes, with foreign government procurement authorities. The ability to manage technical requirements under government oversight, respond to government review comments formally, and achieve acceptance on a schedule commitment is daily mid-level work in Hanwha Aerospace's defence divisions. Engineers who have only worked in commercial environments without government programme experience are missing this capability.

Done Signal: You have a story about working on a programme with a government or military customer — whether DAPA, a US DoD agency, a European MoD, or equivalent — where you prepared technical evidence, responded to a government review comment or requirement challenge, and formal acceptance was achieved. The story names the specific government body and the type of technical deliverable.

12. Understand the K9 Thunder's Global Export Success and What Engineering Challenges Come with Localised Production and Customer-Specific Variants 3 h

Skill: Export programme engineering awareness for Hanwha Aerospace's globally dominant land systems product

Objective: The K9 Thunder is in service in 10 countries including Poland, Romania, India, and others — in 2025 alone Poland signed additional chassis supply agreements and India signed a second K9 contract. This export success creates engineering challenges around localised production (transferring manufacturing technology to partner countries), customer-specific variants (different ammunition compatibility, crew interface, communication systems), and in-country support contracts. Engineers who understand the engineering dimension of defence export — offset agreements, technol-

ogy transfer, variant management, overseas MRO — are directly relevant to the fastest-growing part of Hanwha Aerospace's business. 3 h

Done Signal: You can explain what the K9 Thunder is (155mm self-propelled howitzer, world #1 market share, K10 ammunition carrier variant), why it has achieved such export success compared to competitors, what engineering challenges arise when a customer requires a country-specific variant, and what *jeolchung gyoyeok* (offset trade / industrial cooperation) means in the context of Korean defence exports. You can do this in Korean.

13. Prepare a Specific Answer to “Wae Hanwha Aerospace inga?” (Why Hanwha Aerospace?) That Connects to National Technology Sovereignty 2 h

Skill: Institution-specific motivation that engages with Hanwha Aerospace's unique Korean identity

Objective: The “why Hanwha Aerospace” question is asked in every Korean interview at every level. The expected answer at Hanwha Aerospace specifically engages with the “Great Challenger” identity — the company's role as the only Korean private company developing gas turbine engines, as system integrator for Korea's national launch vehicle, as the engineering backbone of Korea's defence self-reliance. Generic “I want to work in aerospace” answers that could apply to KAI or any other Korean aerospace company do not differentiate. The expected answer names a specific Hanwha Aerospace capability that exists nowhere else in Korea and explains why you want to be part of building it.

Done Signal: You have a 90-second answer in Korean that names one specific Hanwha Aerospace technical capability (gas turbine engine indigenous development, KSLV system integration, KF-21 engine development, K9 export programme), explains why this capability matters for Korean national technology sovereignty, connects your engineering background to contributing to it, and does not contain a sentence that could apply to a different Korean aerospace or defence company.

Suchok / Senior and Principal Engineer

All mid-level tasks still apply. Korean language must be at C1 or higher for technical leadership roles. The PT presentation must demonstrate technical leadership, not just technical execution. DAPA knowledge (task 9) must be operational — you should have led a programme review with DAPA, not just attended one.

14. Prepare to Walk Through a Complete Gas Turbine Component or Launch Vehicle Subsystem Development Lifecycle — from Aerodynamic or Structural Design Through Rig Test Acceptance 4–6 h

Skill: End-to-end development ownership in the specific Korean technical context

Objective: Senior Hanwha Aerospace engineers are expected to own full development threads for engine components or launch vehicle subsystems — from specification through design, analysis, manufacturing, rig testing, and customer acceptance. The specific Korean context adds a dimension: much of this work is being done for the first time in Korea, with limited institutional precedent. The interview at this level is a probe of whether you have actually owned a thread like this — in an environment where the institutional knowledge is still being built and where the engineering judgement of individuals is irreplaceable.

Done Signal: For one gas turbine component or launch vehicle subsystem you personally owned the development thread for, you can answer without notes at every phase — the design requirement, the aerodynamic or structural trade-off, the analysis methods used, the rig test strategy, the critical anomaly encountered and how it was resolved, and the final acceptance criteria. You can describe the institutional challenge of doing this for the first time in Korea without the benefit of precedent.

15. Prepare a Technically Grounded Position on Korea's Next-Generation Launch Vehicle (KSLV-III) Challenges — Specifically Reusability 4 h

Skill: Next-generation space launch programme technical engagement at the level Hanwha Aerospace's engineers discuss it

Objective: In 2024, the South Korean government selected Hanwha Aerospace as system integrator for KSLV-III — developing reusable launch vehicle technology and accumulating knowledge for high-performance new launch vehicle design and manufacture, with commercial launch services as the eventual goal. Senior engineers in propulsion, structures, GNC, or systems who can engage with the specific engineering challenges of KSLV-III — what reusability requires technically, how the lessons from Falcon 9 or New Shepard inform the Korean approach, what Korea can and cannot replicate independently — are demonstrating the forward-looking technical leadership Hanwha Aerospace needs.

Done Signal: You have a prepared 3-minute technical discussion of one specific engineering challenge in KSLV-III development — the challenge is named specifically (reusable first-stage thermal protection during reentry, landing propulsion and GNC for vertical landing, engine reuse certification without the flight heritage Falcon 9 has, or propellant choice for reusability). Your position is technically grounded and connects to your engineering background.

16. Prepare Examples of Building or Transferring a Technical Capability That Korea Previously Lacked — Your Specific Contribution to National Technology Sovereignty 2 h

Skill: Technical legacy contribution in a national aerospace sovereignty context

Objective: Korea's aerospace and defence technical capability is not inherited — it is being built, largely within the lifetimes of current engineers, through deliberate programmes of technology transfer, indigenous development, and capability accumulation. Senior Hanwha Aerospace engineers are part of this construction project. The specific probe at senior level is not “what did you build?” but “what can Korea now do that it could not do before you worked on it?” Engineers who have transferred a specific technical capability — from RSP work, from KARI collaboration, from overseas experience — and can point to a programme outcome that demonstrates Korea's new capability are demonstrating exactly the senior value that Hanwha Aerospace most needs.

Done Signal: You have a story where your engineering work contributed to a capability that Korea previously lacked — a first indigenisation, a first rig test of a component previously purchased from abroad, a first application of a simulation method previously unavailable in Korea. The story names the specific capability, its prior absence, your contribution, and the programme artefact that demonstrates Korea's new capability.

17. Prepare to Discuss the KF-21 Boramae Engine Development Challenge — and What Full Engine Indigenisation Would Require 3–4 h

Skill: Korea's flagship fighter programme propulsion technology agenda

Objective: In 2024, Hanwha Aerospace signed a \$401 million contract with DAPA to supply engines for the first mass-production batch of the KF-21, while also working through a GE partnership to develop an integrated engine and localise key components. The GE partnership structure — which provides access to technology but ultimately limits full Korean design authority — is the core tension in the KF-21 engine programme. Senior engineers who can articulate what full engine indigenisation would require technically (combustion chemistry expertise, turbine cooling technology, materials for hot section, engine control software), what Korea currently has and what it still needs, and how Hanwha Aerospace's RSP experience contributes to closing that gap, are demonstrating the strategic technical thinking that senior programme leadership requires.

Done Signal: You can explain the current KF-21 engine configuration (GE F414 derivative, partnership structure with Hanwha Aerospace), what *engin guksan-hwa* (engine indigenisation) would require to achieve full Korean design authority, what specific technical capabilities Korea currently lacks compared to GE, and how Hanwha Aerospace's RSP programme experience with GENX and GTF is building the component technology base needed for a fully indigenous engine within 10–15 years.

3–4 h

18. Build Quantitative Estimation Fluency for Gas Turbine Performance Parameters — Without a Simulation Deck

4 h

Skill: Engineering first-principles reasoning at senior Korean aerospace pace

Objective: Senior Hanwha Aerospace engineers are expected to sanity-check analysis results from younger engineers and from partner organisations, catch errors in supplier deliverables, and respond credibly to “does this number make sense?” in fast-moving programme review meetings with DAPA officials. For a gas turbine company: estimating stage loading for a compressor stage from velocity triangle considerations, estimating turbine inlet temperature required for a given thrust level, estimating blade life from a simplified creep model. None of these requires a CFD simulation to estimate at order-of-magnitude if thermodynamic fundamentals are solid.

Done Signal: You have worked through five gas turbine performance or component estimation problems in Korean — stated out loud, assumptions named before numbers — arriving at order-of-magnitude answers with stated uncertainty. You can identify which assumption is most load-bearing in each and how you would verify it with rig test data.

All Levels

19. Prepare a Specific Answer to “Wae Hanwha Aerospace ga segye jeok gieob gwa gyeongjaenghal su issna?” — Why Can Hanwha Aerospace Compete Globally?

2 h

Skill: Strategic self-awareness about Korea's aerospace competitive position — a values and context filter at all levels

Objective: This question, or variants of it, tests whether candidates understand both Hanwha Aerospace's genuine strengths and its honest limitations relative to GE, Rolls-Royce, Lockheed Martin, or BAE Systems. Candidates who only describe Hanwha Aerospace's strengths are demonstrating either naivety or insufficient preparation. Candidates who only describe limitations are demonstrating a lack of faith in the mission. The expected answer names specific competitive advantages (K9 artillery: undisputed #1 globally; KSLV system integration: Korea-unique; RSP partnerships: world-class component manufacturing validation), acknowledges where gaps remain, and explains the strategy for closing them.

Done Signal: You have a 90-second answer that names two specific Hanwha Aerospace competitive advantages with supporting evidence, acknowledges one specific technology gap relative to Western OEMs, and describes one specific mechanism by which Hanwha Aerospace is closing that gap. The answer is neither promotional nor defeatist — it is strategically honest. You can deliver it in Korean.

20. Verify Korean Language Proficiency, Military Service Status (for Korean Male Applicants), and Security Clearance Eligibility for Defence Roles

1–2 h

Skill: Eligibility self-knowledge for the three most common application-blocking factors

Objective: Three factors frequently block candidates who have not researched them: Korean language proficiency (TOPIK Level 4 or higher required for international student applications; profes-

sional working level required for all Korean-site roles), military service status (Korean males must have completed or be exempt from mandatory service), and security clearance eligibility for defence sector employment (background verification under Korean information security laws applies to all Hanwha Aerospace employees due to its defence industry status). Candidates who discover any of these barriers after investing significant application effort have not done their pre-application research.

1–2 h

Done Signal: You know your TOPIK level or equivalent Korean proficiency, have confirmed military service status if applicable, have researched what Hanwha Aerospace's defence industry security requirements mean for your background (foreign contacts, overseas residence, dual nationality), and can answer all three eligibility questions clearly and without hesitation in a recruiter screen.

SUMMARY REFERENCE TABLE

#	Task Description	Target Level	Effort
1	HAT aptitude test — numerical, verbal, spatial, SJT under timed conditions	All	4–6 h
2	Korean technical vocabulary — professional working level	All	Months
3	PT (<i>balpyo myeonjeop</i>) presentation in Korean — technical background	All	5–6 h
4	Four division knowledge — Aerospace, Space, Land, Defence Electronics	All	5–6 h
5	<i>Jagi sogaeseo</i> essays — Hanwha-specific values and Great Challenger	All	4–5 h
6	Nuri (KSLV-II) programme and Hanwha Aerospace's system integrator role	All	3 h
7	Korean GTE programmes — KF-21, KUH Surion, RSP partnerships	Mid+	4–5 h
8	Gas turbine component design/analysis story — Korea capability gap	Mid+	2–3 h
9	DAPA (<i>Bangwi Saueop Cheong</i>) and Korean defence acquisition process	Mid+	3–4 h
10	RSP (Risk Sharing Partner) model and strategic technology development	Mid+	3 h
11	Government programme interface story	Mid+	1–2 h
12	K9 Thunder export success and variant engineering challenges	Mid+	3 h
13	" <i>Wae Hanwha Aerospace inga?</i> " — national sovereignty, programme-specific	Mid+	2 h
14	Full GTE component or launch vehicle subsystem development walk-through	Senior	4–6 h
15	KSLV-III reusability challenges — technical position	Senior	4 h
16	Technical capability contribution to Korea's first — indigenous development	Senior	2 h
17	KF-21 engine indigenisation — current status and future requirements	Senior	3–4 h
18	Gas turbine performance estimation — five problems in Korean	Senior	4 h
19	Global competitiveness — honest strengths and gaps	All	2 h
20	TOPIK, military service, and security clearance eligibility verification	All	1–2 h

THE STRUCTURAL REALITY

Every other company in this guide operates in a domain where the technology has existed for decades and the engineering challenge is refinement, extension, or application. Hanwha Aerospace is building things that Korea has never built before — indigenous gas turbine engines, autonomous launch vehicle systems, hypersonic test vehicles, and the institutional knowledge that allows a nation to sustain these capabilities independently rather than purchasing them from foreign suppliers.

The engineers who succeed at Hanwha Aerospace are those who find genuine meaning in this specific mission — who understand that working on Korea's first indigenous fighter engine or its first fully sovereign launch vehicle means contributing to something that will define Korea's technological independence for a generation. The ones who struggle are those who join expecting a replication of GE or Airbus culture and discover instead a company that is building its own engineering tradition from the ground up, in Korean, at the pace of a nation catching up with 70 years of Western aerospace development in 25.

The candidates who succeed are those who understand both halves of that sentence — the ambition and the pace — and find both genuinely compelling.

————— BREAK INTO AEROSPACE —————